MOREH NEVUCHIM

When God Returns to His Place: Yasa, Shav, Halakh & Hashgahah

Given Tuesday 3 November 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:23-24

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed), Section 1 **Chapters:** I:23 — **יצא** (to go out) and **שב** (to return); I:24 — **הלך** (to go) **Shiur:** Tuesday 3 November 2026, 8:00pm, on Zoom **Schedule note:** The Rabbi hoped to cover Chapters 23, 24 and 25 tonight. Chapters 23 and 24 were completed; Chapter 25 (**שכן**, to dwell) moves to next week.

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are

Last week we completed **Chapter 21**, the word **עבר** (to pass), which took a couple of weeks. It covered the whole passage in **פרשת כי תשא** where we say the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy. We saw five meanings of the word **עבר** across the Torah and four ways of reading the verses, and we worked through the passage according to each one.

We then learned **Chapter 22**, the word **בא** (to come), which has four meanings:

#	Meaning of בא	Physical?
1	Physical movement towards something	Yes
2	Physical movement into something, into a defined place	Yes
3	Something occurring, something being fulfilled	No
4	Even the "coming" of a privation, a negative, such as darkness or evil	No

When **בא** is used of HaKadosh Baruch Hu it can never mean physical movement. It means either His Shechinah becoming manifest, or His words and promises being fulfilled.

Tonight: three verbs

The plan for the evening:

Chapter	Verb	Meaning
23	**יצא** (**שב** and its opposite)	To go out (and to return)
24	**הלך**	To go
25	**שכן**	To dwell (next week)

"These are three relatively short, important chapters, as they all are of course."

Part One — Chapter 23: יצא, "To Go Out"

Why this chapter now

On the simplest level the continuation is obvious. Chapter 22 discussed **בא**, coming, so Chapter 23 discusses its opposite, **יציאה**, going out. The Rambam opens:

פרק כ"ג: היציאה כנגד הביאה *Going out corresponds to coming.*

the two are symmetrical. (The Rabbi later suggested a second ;**ביאה** is the corollary of **יציאה** reason for the placement, in Part Two.)

The two meanings of יצא

Meaning 1: a physical body leaving one place for another.

משמש ליציאת גוף ממקום שהיה נח בו למקום אחר, בין אם הגוף ההוא בעל חיים ובין אם לאו בעל חיים *It is used for a body going out of the place where it was resting to another place, whether that body is a living creature or not.*

A corporeal entity was in one place, resting there, and it went out to a new place. It makes no difference whether it is animate or inanimate.

- **Living beings: הם יצאו את העיר לא הרחיקו** (Bereishit 44:4). This is the end of **פרשת מקץ**. The brothers, the **שבטים**, had just left Yosef's home, and Yosef commanded that they be pursued. "They, that's human beings, left. They were in one place, in Yosef's home, and they moved and they left. They went out to a new place."
- **Non-living things: כי תצא אש** (Shemot 22:5), in **פרשת משפטים**. If fire goes out and consumes a stack of grain, you have to pay. "The fire is going out from place A into place B, although the fire is not a **בעל חיים**, it's not a living organism."

"That's the first meaning. That is pretty straightforward and clear."

Meaning 2: the appearance of something that is not a body.

והושאל להופעת דבר שאינו גוף *It was borrowed for the appearance of something that is not a body.*

The Rambam's examples:

הדבר יצא מפי המלך ופני המן חפו (Esther 7:8). As soon as Achashverosh suspected Haman of acting inappropriately with Esther, "the matter came out of the king's mouth," and Haman's face was covered. "What does it mean, the word came out of the mouth of Achashverosh? It doesn't mean literally something came out. It's not talking about the sound waves." The matter came out in a metaphorical sense.

כי יצא דבר המלכה על כל הנשים להבזות בעליהן בעיניהן (Esther 1:17). Memuchan, Achashverosh's adviser, warns that when word of what the queen did gets out, women will belittle their husbands. "There are no words travelling from one place to another place like the brothers travelled, or even like the fire travels. What it means is that the matter will spread." The Rambam: **כלומר התפשטות הדבר**, the spreading of the matter, its publicity.

כי מציון תצא תורה ודבר ה' מירושלים (Yeshayahu 2:3). What, Torah's going to walk out? It's going to creep out? No, it's going to be publicised from Tziyon."

from last week's parasha. Lot reached Tzoar ,(Bereishit 19:23) **השמש יצא על הארץ ולוט בא צוערה** the appearance of the light. **כלומר הופעת האור**, :just as the sun had come out. The Rambam .The sun is not literally coming out; the light is spreading

Summary of the two meanings

#	Meaning of יצא	Examples	Physical?
1	A body leaving one place for another, animate or inanimate	**הם יצאו את העיר**; **כי תצא אש**	Yes
2	The appearance or spreading of something non-corporeal	**הדבר יצא מפי המלך**; **כי יצא דבר המלכה**; **כי מציון תצא תורה**; **השמש יצא על הארץ**	No

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Part Two — "Behold, Hashem Is Coming Out of His Place"

The rule

,Whenever the word "going out" is said of Him, may He be exalted **וכל לשון יציאה שנאמרה בו יתעלה**

it must be the second meaning, never the first.

The verse

.Behold, Hashem is coming out of His place — (Michah 1:3) **הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו**

The Rambam explains:

.His word, which is now hidden from us, will appear **יופיע דברו המוסתר כעת מאיתנו**

That is, the bringing into being of what had not yet come into **כלומר, יצירת מה שלא יצא להוויה** *.being*

For everything brought into being by Him is attributed **כי כל היווצרות על ידו יתעלה מיוחסת לדבריו** *,to His word*

as it says, **בדבר ה' שמים נעשו וברוח פיו כל צבאם** (Tehillim 33:6), *by the word of Hashem the heavens were made.*

This is like the actions that **בדמיון לפעולות היוצאות מן המלכים, שהכלי שלהם לביצוע רצונם הוא הדיבור** *.come from kings, whose instrument for carrying out their will is speech*

והוא יתעלה אינו נזקק לכלי לפעול באמצעותו, אלא פעולתו היא רצונו בלבד, וגם אין דיבור כלל כמו
But He, may He be exalted, needs no instrument through which to act; His action is His **שנתבאר** *.will alone. And there is no speech at all, as has been explained*

Adding a word

"You have to add in a word. This is important." The verse **הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו** is to be read as:

.Behold, the word of Hashem is coming out of His place **הנה דבר ה' יוצא ממקומו**

Why the "word" of Hashem means the will of Hashem

Kings and powerful, authoritative people get their will done through speech, through their commands. So when the Torah wants to describe Hashem wanting something done, it speaks of

His word.

- "Not that there is any word with HaKadosh Baruch Hu. That's impossible."
- "And not that Hashem needs the words."
- "Whatever God's **רצון** is, we're not discussing that now. When Hashem's **רצון** wants to be done, it talks about His word."

"So the word of Hashem is the will of Hashem. You understand that?"

What "His place" means

We learned in **Chapter 8** of the Moreh that **מקום**, used of Hashem, means His special status, His exalted standing.

Before the event, the will of Hashem was **מוסתר**, hidden, concealed, still "in its place", in its special status with the will of HaKadosh Baruch Hu. When Hashem wants it to be manifested, it comes out. "The word of Hashem comes out and is manifested from its original **מקום**, its original special status. It comes out from there and is manifested, is publicised."

So **יוצא**, used of Hashem, means: becoming readily apparent, manifested, publicised.

A second reason for the chapter's placement

The Rabbi suggested another reason why the Rambam brings this chapter now. In Chapter 21 the Rambam conceded to Onkelos that sometimes words must be added to a verse; Onkelos added **יקרא** / **שכינה**, and the Rambam himself added **קול**. In Chapter 22 the Rambam added a word too. **הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו** read as **הנה דבר ה' יוצא ממקומו** is another example of the same principle: "sometimes verses have to have words added to them."

Summary of the argument

Step	
The verse	**הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו**
Read it as	the word of Hashem is coming out — **הנה דבר ה' יוצא ממקומו**
"Word" means	The will of Hashem (as kings act through their words)
"His place" means	His special, exalted status, where the will was concealed (Chapter 8)
"Coming out" means	Becoming manifest, apparent, publicised (meaning 2)

Part Three — שב: The Other Opposite of יצא

Two opposites

The final paragraph of the chapter is "very important. It's an introduction to something which we'll learn much later, but it starts making us think."

יצא has two opposites:

Pair	Verse	Source
going out — **יצא / בא** and coming in	**לא אוכל עוד לצאת ולבוא** — *I can no longer go out and come in*	Moshe at 120 (Devarim 31:2)
going out — **יצא / שב** and returning	**ויצא יצוא ושוב עד יבשת המים מעל הארץ** — *it went out, going out and returning, until the waters dried up*	Noach's raven (Bereishit 8:7)

The Rambam on שב

וכיוון שיציאה הושאלה להופעת פעולה מפעולותיו, כמו שביארנו בנאמר ה' יוצא ממקומו *Since "going out" was borrowed for the appearance of one of His actions, as we explained regarding "Hashem is coming out of His place",*

הושאלה גם שיבה להסתלקות אותה פעולה בעת הימנע רצון האלוהי *"returning" was also borrowed for the withdrawal of that action when the divine will is withheld.*

יציאה means Hashem's will becoming more manifested. **שיבה** means it going back, returning to its original place, no longer manifested.

"I will go and return to My place"

וכן נאמר: אלכה ואשובה אל מקומי (Hoshea 5:15)

"How beautiful!" (The Rabbi set aside **אלכה** until Chapter 24.)

המשמעות היא הסתלקות מאתנו של השכינה שהייתה בינינו *The meaning is the withdrawal from us of the Shechinah that had been among us.*

"I will return to My place" means: I will return to being aloof from you, to My special status. "**הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו** — Hashem is coming out from His aloofness. What was concealed is becoming readily manifested, public and apparent. No, no, no. When you misbehave, **אשובה אל מקומי**, I will go back to my aloofness, I will go back to my special status, I will leave you."

What the withdrawal means: the loss of hashgacha

המובילה להעדר השגחה עלינו *which leads to the absence of providence over us.*

As it says in the curses:

ועזבתים והסתרתי פני מהם והיה לאכול ומצאוהו רעות רבות וצרות (Devarim 31:17) *I will forsake them and hide My face from them, and they will be devoured, and many evils and troubles will find them.*

"You turn your face from Me, I will turn My face from you. That means I'm not being **משגיח**."

The biggest curse: randomness

משום שאם תעדר השגחה, יופקר, ויעשה מטרה לכל מה שיוכל לקרות *For if providence is absent, a person is abandoned and becomes a target for anything that may happen.*

והטוב והרע שיבוא עליו יהיה כפי המקרה *and the good and the bad that come upon him will be by chance.*

כמה קשה איום זה *How terrible a threat this is!*

The Rabbi highlighted two points.

1. Without hashgacha, life is not necessarily bad. It is random.

"Notice, when Hashem leaves His hashgacha from you, it doesn't mean you're going to have a bad life. It could be you'll have a good life. But it's random. Good or bad which happens to you is completely coincidental. It could be you'll have everything good, but it's luck. The good which you have can change any moment due to randomness."

2. It is not a punishment. It is measure for measure.

"This isn't a punishment. It's simply **מידה כנגד מידה**," something the Rambam touched on in the very first chapter. "You turn your face from Hashem, you turn your interest from Hashem, Hashem turns His face from you. Simple as that."

"Until they seek My face"

The verse in Hoshea continues: **אלך ואשובה אל מקומי עד אשר יאשמו ובקשו פני** — *until they acknowledge their guilt and seek My face.*

"It's so beautiful, Rambam, it's so precise. I am going back to my aloofness because you're not interested in me. But if **בקשו פני**, if you want my face, if you want my hashgacha, if you want to be involved with me, I'll come back. It's as simple as that."

The Rambam will discuss hashgacha in great detail later in the Moreh. "This is not the place to go into the Rambam's **שיטה** of hashgacha, that's a whole discussion in itself. But in short, the Rambam holds, very simply: if you seek Hashem, you get Hashem. If you don't, you're left to randomness." Hashgacha is commensurate with a person's own desire for a relationship with HaKadosh Baruch Hu: "The more a person wants there to be hashgacha, the more there will be hashgacha."

Why sometimes בא and sometimes שב?

Pair	When it is used	Example
יציאה / ביאה	Leaving A to arrive at B	Moshe: "I can't go out of the desert and come into Kena'an" — **לצאת ולבוא**
יציאה / שיבה	Leaving A for B, then coming back to A	The raven goes out of the ark into the sky and comes back to the ark — **יצוא ושוב**

(On **לא אוכל עוד לצאת ולבוא** there are many explanations; the Rabbi used the simplest: "I can't go out from the desert and I can't come into Yisrael.")

Applied to HaKadosh Baruch Hu, "it makes beautiful sense":

"Naturally, I am aloof. I'm HaKadosh Baruch Hu. I'm giving you a favour. I'm giving you some of My hashgacha, some of My light, some of My presence. I'm coming out, making Myself accessible and manifested to you. You don't want that? I will return to My place. I'm coming out from A to B, making Myself accessible to human beings. You don't want that? I will go back to **מקומי**, to being exalted and aloof from human beings."

	יצא of Hashem	שב of Hashem
Verse	**הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו**	**אלכה ואשובה אל מקומי**
Meaning	His will becomes manifest, accessible	His will returns to concealment; His Shechinah withdraws
For us	Hashgacha	Absence of hashgacha: randomness
When	—	When we turn our face from Him
Reversed when	—	**ובקשו פני** — when we seek Him

Part Four — "And Avraham Returned to His Place"

The Rabbi ended the chapter with a verse from last week's parasha, Vayera.

After Avraham's long negotiation with HaKadosh Baruch Hu over Sedom, "forwards and backwards, having a dialogue, he thinks he's got a point", the parasha ends:

> **וילך ה' כאשר כלה לדבר אל אברהם ואברהם שב למקומו** (Bereishit 18:33) *Hashem went when He had finished speaking to Avraham, and Avraham returned to his place.*

"What does that mean? He goes back to his place, his place of what? Of being a human being who can't argue with God."

"Until now, Avraham came out: the big negotiator, the challenger of HaKadosh Baruch Hu. Incredible. He tries. Unsuccessful. **ואברהם שב למקומו**. Avraham returns back to his place. What's your place? You're a human being. Go back to your place." We have the same idiom in English: to put someone in their place.

The Rabbi noted that this is his own reading, not one the Rambam gives: "That was a thought. I was reading Vayera and thought of that."

From the class

Doron pointed out that this explains why both **שב** and **מקומו** must be read this way. Avraham was talking with Hashem, possibly in a vision. "What on earth does it mean, **ואברהם שב למקומו**? It was a dream. Where did he go that he needs to come back from?" The Rabbi agreed: "Exactly. It was a dream. So he returned back to his status. All these years we've been reading this verse. What does this mean, Avraham returned to his place? Now it makes absolute, perfect sense based on what we've learned in Rambam."

A second participant asked whether **מקום** must mean *special* status, or simply one's status relative to another. The Rabbi checked Chapter 8 with the class: the Rambam brings both usages, as in **פלוני במקום פלוני**. "In the context of HaKadosh Baruch Hu it means special status. In the context of others, it just means your status. Correct, very good." So Avraham goes back to his status relative to Hashem, the lower status of "a regular human being, not arguing with the divine."

"Avraham was willing to challenge the divine, **חלילה לך**. That was special, that was a coming out, that was unusual. But now he comes back to his place, comes back to being a human being, and recognising you can't challenge HaKadosh Baruch Hu."

Summary of Chapter 23

יציאה is the counterpart of (going out) **ביאה** (coming), Chapter 22.

2. It has two meanings: (1) a body, living or not, leaving one place for another; (2) the appearance and spreading of something non-corporeal.
3. Used of Hashem it is always the second meaning. **הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו** = **הנה דבר ה' יוצא ממקומו**: His word, which is His will, comes out of its concealment in His exalted status and becomes manifest.

שב is a second opposite of (returning) **יצא**. Used of Hashem, **אלכה ואשובה אל מקומי** means the withdrawal of His Shechinah and hashgacha.

5. Without hashgacha a person is left to randomness. Good or bad comes by chance. This is not a punishment but **מידה כנגד מידה**, and it is reversed the moment we seek Him: **ובקשו פני**.

יצא / בא is used for going from A to B; **יצא / שב** for going from A to B and back to A.

7. The Rabbi's application: **ואברהם שב למקומו** — Avraham returns to his status as a human being after challenging the divine.

"Think about it. Go over this. There's a lot more which can be said about it. Whenever we see the words **יצא** or **שב** or **בא**, think about why that specific word has been used, especially when it's in the context of HaKadosh Baruch Hu."

Part Five — Chapter 24: הלך, "To Go"

Why this chapter now

"Now that makes total sense." We have had **בא**, coming (22), and **יצא**, going out (23), and Chapter 23 quoted **אלכה ואשובה**. Having explained **אשובה**, the Rambam now explains **אלכה**: what does "I will go" mean?

גם הליכה היא מכלל המונחים שנקבעו לתנועה מסוימת מתנועת בעלי חיים *"Going" too is one of the terms coined for a particular movement of living creatures.*

The four meanings of הלך

The Rabbi took three now and the fourth at the end of the chapter, as the Rambam does.

Meaning 1: a living creature moving from place to place.

ויעקב הלך לדרכו ויפגעו בו מלאכי אלהים (Bereishit 32:2), which we will read in a couple of weeks. "Human beings moving, going from one place to another place." The Rambam adds this, **וזה נפוץ** is very common.

Meaning 2: the spreading and extending of bodies subtler than those of living creatures.

מונח זה הושאל להתפשטות והימתחות של גופים שהם דקים יותר מגופי בעלי חיים

והמים היו הלוך וחסור עד החדש העשירי (Bereishit 8:5). The waters "went and decreased" for a few months. "Where are they going? They're going in the sense they are decreasing. They are moving."

וה' נתן קלת וברד ותהלך אש ארצה (Shemot 9:23), in **פרשת וארא**, the plague of hail: fire went down to the earth.

"Those are both corporeal things, although one is more subtle than the other."

Meaning 3: the spreading of something, even something not corporeal at all.

לאחר מכן הושאל להתפשטות דבר כל שהוא והפצתו, גם אם אינו גשמי כלל

קולה כנחש ילך (Yirmiyahu 46:22). Yirmiyahu prophesies that the Egyptians will suffer so greatly that their voice will go like a snake. "Just like a snake is heard everywhere — you can be very far and you hear the hissing of the snake and you get scared — so too the Egyptians will be in so much pain and distress that their voice will be heard everywhere."

וישמעו את קול ה' אלהים מתהלך בגן לרוח היום (Bereishit 3:8). The Rambam: **הקול הוא שנאמר שהיה מתהלך**, it is the voice that is said to be walking. "It's not that they heard God in the garden. That's a wrong reading of the verse. They heard the voice of Hashem going in the garden."

Sound waves. The Rabbi noted that today we might say a voice "goes" in the sense that sound waves travel. "They didn't know that then. Sound waves are not apparent to the naked eye." The Rambam, without the concept of sound waves, treats a voice "going" as something non-physical spreading.

Meaning 4: walking in upright ways (see Part Eight).

#	Meaning of הלך	Examples	Physical?
1	Movement of a living creature from place to place	**ויעקב הלך לדרכו**	Yes
2	Spreading of subtler bodies (water, fire)	**והמים היו הלוך וחסור**; **ותהלך אש ארצה**	Yes, though subtle
3	Spreading of something non-corporeal	**קולה כנחש ילך**; **קול ה' אלהים מתהלך בגן**	No
4	Walking in upright, moral ways	**והלכת בדרכיו**	No — and said of people, not of God

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Part Six — הלך Said of Hashem

The rule

לפי השאלה זו, כל לשון הליכה שנאמרה בה' יתעלה *"According to this borrowing, every use of "going" said of Hashem, may He be exalted,*

is the third meaning, something non-corporeal. It means one of two things:

אם להתפשטות הדבר, אם לסילוק השגחה *either the spreading of a matter, or the removal of providence.*

Why "going" can mean removing hashgacha

Spreading is easy to understand: when something goes, it spreads. But why should going mean the removal of hashgacha?

שבעל חיים דומה לכך — הפנייה לאחור מדבר מה, דבר שבעל חיים עושה בהליכה *Because a living creature, when it walks, turns its back on something.*

"When you walk in a certain direction, you turn your back to the other direction. If I walk here now, I'm turning my back to you." So **הלוך** can mean "I'm removing My hashgacha. I'm turning, I'm going from you."

The Rambam ties this to the language of the hidden face:

> **כשם שכינה את הסרת ההשגחה הסרת פנים** — just as Scripture calls the removal of providence "the hiding of the face":
>
> **ואנכי הסתר אסתיר פני ביום ההוא על כל הרעה אשר עשה כי פנה אל אלהים אחרים** (Devarim 31:18) *I will surely hide My face on that day, because he turned to other gods.*

"Because *you* turned your face." Just as it is called turning the face, **כך כינה אותה הליכה**, so too it is called going: **שיש משמעות שפניה לאחור מדבר מה**, which means turning away from something.

ועל זה נאמר: אלך ואשובה אל מקומי

"I will go and I will return": the same thing twice

The Rabbi noted (citing a commentator) that, according to Chapters 23 and 24 together, **אלך ואשובה אל מקומי** turns out to be a repetition. "Not a difficulty, but something we should be aware of."

Word	Chapter	Meaning used of Hashem
אלך — I will go	24	I will turn away — like a creature that walks off and turns its back — and remove My hashgacha
ואשובה אל מקומי — and I will return to My place	23	I will return to My aloofness, My exaltedness, and remove My hashgacha

"It's two words, but saying exactly the same thing." The verse means: "I will doubly leave My hashgacha, and go back to My exaltedness and to My aloofness."

Part Seven — "Hashem's Anger Burned Against Them, and He Went"

Both meanings at once

ויחר אף ה' בם וילך (Bamidbar 12:9) *The anger of Hashem burned against them, and He went.*

This is the story of Aharon, Miriam and Moshe. Miriam and Aharon spoke negatively about Moshe. Hashem came and reprimanded them: "Why did you speak about My servant Moshe? **בכל ביתי נאמן הוא**." Then: "the anger of Hashem burned against them, and He went." The next verse says Miriam was stricken with tzara'at.

("Leave **חרון אף** aside. We're not discussing anger now.")

הרי בהם נמצאו שתי משמעות גם יחד *Here both meanings are found together.*

Meaning	In this verse
סילוק השגחה, המכונה פנייה לאחור — removal of providence, called turning away	Hashem "went": He turned away and took His hashgacha from them
התפשטות הדבר והתגלותו — the spreading of the matter and its appearance	**שחרון האף הלך והתפשט על שניהם, ולכך הפכה מרים מצורעת כשלג** — the anger went out and spread over the two of them, and so Miriam became leprous as snow

"There's something deep here. Let's work this through slowly." Hashem went: He took His hashgacha away from them. And the anger of Hashem spread, diffused, upon them, "which caused consequences, one of them being that Miriam had leprosy."

The question

"If we've been listening to what we've been learning this evening about hashgacha, what question should we have on this?"

We learned in Chapter 23 that the absence of hashgacha means randomness, not punishment. So if Hashem was removing His hashgacha, why is there a *directed* punishment of tzara'at?

The Rabbi's answer

"What the Rambam is saying here, I think, is that **הליכה** means the removal of hashgacha. And as a result of the lack of hashgacha, the randomness spreads and causes the leprosy. Because Hashem takes His hashgacha, this causes the effect in the humans."

Why Miriam and not Aharon?

"Have you ever thought, in this whole story, why is it that **והנה מרים מצורעת כשלג**? Why specifically did Miriam get leprosy and not Aharon?"

Explanation	Reasoning
The simple answer	The verse begins **ותדבר מרים ואהרן במשה**. Miriam spoke first; she initiated, so it happened to her
The Rabbi's reading of the Rambam	Hashem "went," leaving His hashgacha; the lack of hashgacha means negative things and randomness spread; "randomly Miriam gets tzara'at and not Aharon"
The Kuzari (II:62), by contrast	All tzara'at, and physical ailments in general, are a directed punishment

"I don't understand that for the Rambam, because for the Rambam there's no directed punishment. It's the opposite. It's the lack of hashgacha which causes bad things to happen to you." The anger "bore fruit, bore consequences, it diffused. The anger diffused to make Miriam have tzara'at." The Rabbi invited the class to offer a different interpretation if anyone had one.

Part Eight — The Fourth Meaning: Walking in His Ways

וכן הושאל לשון הליכה להליכה בהנהגות נעלות, בלי תואר גוף כלל *"Going" was also borrowed for walking in exalted ways of conduct, with no bodily sense at all.*

This meaning has nothing to do with God's actions. It is about a human being walking with morality, "which is why he puts it right at the end." Examples:

והלכת בדרכיו (Devarim 28:9) — you shall walk in His ways

אחרי ה' אלהיכם תלכו ואותו תיראו (Devarim 13:5) — after Hashem your God you shall walk

לכו ונלכה באור ה' (Yeshayahu 2:5) — come, let us walk in the light of Hashem

Rav Makbili: why the chapter ends here

Rav Makbili "beautifully points out" why the Rambam adds this at the end: this kind of behaviour causes the hashgacha of Hashem to rest upon us. "So there won't be **הליכה**, there won't be **שיבה** of the previous chapter. If we walk in this path, **לכו ונלכה באור ה'**, **והלכת בדרכיו**, then you won't have Hashem's **הליכה**, you won't have His **שיבה**."

When we walk in His ways, He does not walk away from us.

Summary of Chapter 24

1. **הלך** has four meanings: (1) a creature moving from place to place; (2) the spreading of subtler bodies like water and fire; (3) the spreading, the diffusion, of something non-corporeal, such as a voice; (4) walking in upright, moral ways.
2. Used of Hashem it is always the third meaning, and it means either the spreading of something, or turning away, the removal of hashgacha, just as a creature that walks off turns its back.
3. **אלך ואשובה אל מקומי** therefore says the same thing twice: "I will turn away, and I will return to My aloofness."
4. **ויחר אף ה' בם וילך** has both meanings at once: Hashem removed His hashgacha, and His anger spread over them. In the Rabbi's reading, Miriam's tzara'at came about through the randomness that follows the withdrawal of hashgacha, rather than as a directed punishment, in contrast to the Kuzari.
5. The fourth meaning, walking in Hashem's ways, is what brings His hashgacha upon us, so that He does not "go" or "return".

Summary: Three Verbs Used of Hashem

Verb	Chapter	Opposite	Used of Hashem means	Key verse
to — **בא** come	22	**יצא**	His Shechinah resting; His word being fulfilled	**הנה אנכי בא אליך בעב הענן**
to — **יצא** go out	23	**בא**; **שב**	His word, i.e. His will, becoming manifest, coming out of concealment	**הנה ה' יוצא ממקומו**
to — **שב** return	23	**יצא**	His will returning to concealment; the withdrawal of His Shechinah and hashgacha	**אלכה ואשובה אל מקומי**
to — **הלך** go	24	—	Either the spreading of something, or turning away and removing hashgacha (or both)	**אלך ואשובה אל מקומי**; **ויחר אף ה' בם וילך**

The thread running through both chapters: Hashem "comes out" to us when He makes His will and His hashgacha manifest, and "goes" and "returns to His place" when we turn our faces from Him. Without His hashgacha, life is left to chance. It may even be good, but it is random. And the way back is in our hands: **ובקשו פני**, seek His face, and **והלכת בדרכיו**, walk in His ways.

Coming Up

B'Ezrat Hashem, next Tuesday at 8:00pm we will learn **Chapter 25**, **שכן**, to dwell, the root of **שכינה**. After that the Rambam takes a break of about three chapters from discussing verbs and turns to more general topics.

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